NYT Daily Briefing — 2026-11-02

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tl;dr: Two days before the midterms, Republicans are closing on personal attacks and a Democratic congresswoman just endorsed her party's Republican opponent in Michigan. A federal judge threw out the administration's pre-emptive challenge to Alaska's Senate election. President Trump's science agencies are shedding staff and grants faster than they can be replaced. North Korea stole $6.3 billion from Binance, which reopened in three days and absorbed the run. Putin spent the week being welcomed back into diplomacy by the country that organized his isolation. And a South Korean company nobody has heard of now moves half the oil out of the Persian Gulf.

Cluster 1: Geopolitics & International Affairs

Thematic hook: The people who were supposed to be isolated — Putin, Assad's successor, Netanyahu — are the ones currently setting terms.

Articles: #2, #18, #19, #20, #21, #22, #23

Putin's diplomatic breakout, underwritten by Washington (#2): Nearly five years into a war he is not winning, Putin spent the week taking calls from Nordic leaders, hosting Qatar's emir and Iran's president, and telling African heads of state to control their own social media. The substance is American: the administration is considering lifting sanctions on Russia's flagship investment fund, has agreed to import Russian diesel, and sent an envoy who called Putin "a humanitarian." A German analyst's summary is the plainest read available — "no matter what they are doing or not doing, they are getting things they didn't even expect." Putin travels to Shenzhen this month for APEC, where a trilateral with Xi and Trump would put Russia on equal footing with both.

Netanyahu's 27 seats and the arithmetic that no longer works (#18, #22): Likud lost nearly a sixth of its seats and still finished first with 27 — the smallest possible win in a Parliament where 61 is a majority. His bloc leads the opposition by five seats, but Eisenkot's alliance plus two Arab parties commands 67. That makes Israel's Arab lists the hinge of the next government for the first time at this scale, and their price is civil equality, policing in Arab towns, and a ceasefire agenda. Netanyahu can try to buy eight defectors from a bloc sworn to unseat him, or he can offer Eisenkot a unity government; both require credibility he has spent.

The Mecca alliance reaches Damascus (#19): Syria's foreign minister told the Manama Dialogue that "discussions are currently underway to evaluate Syria's entry into the Mecca alliance" — the August mutual-defense pact between Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan that treats an attack on one as an attack on all. Syria says it will "stand beside all of the Gulf countries" against "militias that cross borders," a phrase aimed at the Houthis. Whether that means Syrian troops in Yemen is unresolved, and Damascus has spent two years trying to stay out of regional wars.

One hundred thirty million names gone (#20): Tens of thousands filled Ramlila Ground in New Delhi in what appears to be the largest anti-Modi demonstration since he took office, protesting a voter-roll revision that has expunged more than 130 million names. Rahul Gandhi accused the government of "treason" against Indian democracy and demanded the resignation of the election commissioner Modi appointed. The rally was peaceful, which is itself notable — recent protests have not been.

The largest crypto theft in history, attributed (#21): The F.B.I. named North Korea's TraderTraitor unit as the actor behind this week's Binance hack, the first official attribution in the $6.3 billion case. A 2024 U.N. panel found the regime's cyber operations generate about half its foreign currency income, and Chainalysis says the attackers used A.I. to process "thousands of transactions in a short period." Binance initially blamed a compromised engineer's laptop and later identified "additional points of breach."

Prediction: Israel will not have a sworn government within 90 days, and a second election within 12 months is the likelier path. *(Rationale: Netanyahu's 27 seats require 61, his bloc leads by only five, and the 67-seat opposition alternative runs through two Arab parties whose price he has refused to pay for a decade.)* **Confidence: 52%** (toss-up)

Also in this cluster: Thailand's most-followed snake catcher (#23) has built a media business on urban reptile removals, and his success is a measure of how fast Bangkok's sprawl is pushing wildlife into homes.

Cluster 2: US Politics & Domestic Policy

Thematic hook: With 48 hours left, the campaign has stopped being about programs and become about who is allowed to be on the ballot and who is allowed to count it.

Articles: #3, #4, #5, #6, #8, #9, #10, #11, #12, #14, #15, #16, #17

The closing argument is an insult (#3): Roger Marshall says his opponent "probably is grooming" children. Texas Republicans call James Talarico a "freak." The president calls Abdul El-Sayed a "vicious, violent jihadist." Facing a backlash over prices and the president's unpopularity, the party has chosen base mobilization over persuasion — a trade Jeff Flake, a Republican, calls "a new level" of crassness. The strategic risk is explicit in the reporting: the same lines that energize the base are the ones moderate voters hear as disqualifying.

A Democratic congresswoman endorses the Republican (#4, #15): Haley Stevens withdrew her support for El-Sayed on Sunday and endorsed Mike Rogers, releasing the video while she stood beside him at a Black church in Detroit. The rupture is about Israel and about a streamer El-Sayed campaigned with, but its value to Rogers is not Stevens's voters — it is permission for moderate Democrats to stay home. In a race that decides Senate control, and that both parties are already reading as a proxy for 2028, that permission is the whole prize.

Alaska's judge says no (#5, #12): Chief Judge Sharon Gleason dismissed the Justice Department's suit asking a court to block certification if Senator Daniel S. Sullivan loses to a retired teacher also named Daniel Sullivan. She could not see how the government's remedy would work "given the right to a secret ballot." It is the administration's third election-litigation defeat in a week, after a California court blocked prosecution threats against local officials and a panel refused to set aside 20,000 mail ballots. The same-name trick is now Ballot Measure 2's best argument for repealing ranked-choice voting — a system built precisely to make spoilers impossible.

The silent majority that isn't silent in the data (#6): Women prefer Democrats 56 to 37 in Times/Siena surveys, up from 48–41 in 2022, and vote at higher rates than men. The story's framing — that the biggest, most reliable Democratic bloc is the one nobody is looking at — is the tell. The canvassing in the story is being done by retired women sending postcards in Kent County, Michigan, not by the broadcast buys absorbing half the cycle's ad money.

The election-administration story nobody wants to report (#8): Three-quarters of voters trust the count will be accurate, but the operational story is about the officials: civil rights groups and unions sued to block possible federal agents at polls, and a court had to bar prosecution threats against clerks who do not follow federal ballot directives. "I'm kind of foreseeing that there will be some dirty tricks," said a 77-year-old Maine Democrat, who added she trusts local officials to respond.

A violent holiday, counted (#9): At least 24 dead and 94 wounded in Halloween shootings from California to Delaware, including three in Dallas's Deep Ellum that killed four. Oct. 31 is the third-deadliest day on the American calendar after July 4 and Jan. 1, per an analysis of F.B.I. Boston data, and the deadliest for minors. A 5-year-old in Detroit told her mother, "I think I've been shot," and is in stable condition.

Mortality interrupts a campaign (#10): Senator Chris Murphy, 53, suffered a stroke at his son's hockey game on Saturday and was transferred to Johns Hopkins. His chief of staff says he is "awake and alert" and doctors are "optimistic he will make a full recovery." Murphy is a possible 2028 candidate and had been scheduled to campaign in New Hampshire on Sunday — a reminder, in a week about political positioning, that the body sets its own calendar.

Also in this cluster: Nine people died when a Learjet 60 declared mayday while descending at 20,000 feet per minute and hit a road

near Palm Beach; 600 residents were evacuated (#11). The elite law firms that struck accommodation deals with the administration are staying on the sidelines as voting litigation unfolds (#14). A West Point cadet who pleaded guilty to forcing an abortion on a fellow cadet is now being sued by her in Manhattan (#16). And Mayor Mamdani's push to replace the chair of New York's racial equity commission has supporters asking whether his commitment to reparations survived the feud (#17).

Cluster 3: Business, Tech & Economy

Thematic hook: Concentration is both the profit model and the failure mode — one company in the Strait, one exchange in crypto, one central bank for 21 countries.

Articles: #24, #25, #26, #27, #28, #29, #30, #31, #32

One family now moves half the Gulf's oil (#24): Sinokor controlled 42 very large crude carriers in December and 129 now, and has handled about half of all tanker transits through the Strait of Hormuz since September, according to Lloyd's List Intelligence. The purchases were concentrated in the two months before the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran — a bet so well timed that it deserves scrutiny regardless of what the evidence shows. "They have succeeded in cornering the market," an Arctic Securities analyst says. The consequence is a structural freight-rate floor: even as volumes recover, the tonnage is in one firm's hands.

Prediction: Sinokor's share of Hormuz tanker transits will remain above 40 percent through the first quarter of 2027. *(Rationale: 129 VLCCs are a physical asset base that cannot be divested quickly, and tonnage concentration persists through the winter shipping cycle even if war risk falls.)* **Confidence: 72%** (high confidence)

Binance passes its stress test (#25): Three days after a $6.3 billion theft, the exchange reopened withdrawals and took a $3.64 billion outflow — 2.1 percent of its $171 billion in assets — which then stabilized. It froze about $3 billion of the stolen funds with partners and said it will cover all losses. The number that matters is the percentage, not the absolute: the largest crypto heist in history produced a bank-run-sized scare that the exchange absorbed in a weekend.

Trump loses the $10 billion suit, again (#26): Judge Darrin Gayles dismissed the president's defamation case against The Wall Street Journal with prejudice, ruling he "failed" to show actual malice over the 2025 story about a birthday note to Jeffrey Epstein. The opinion's line is worth keeping: the president argues that once he called the letter a "fake," the paper should have "disregarded everything else they learned in their investigation" — which, the judge wrote, "runs afoul of the First Amendment."

The ECB's succession, with 21 principals and no enforcement (#27): Christine Lagarde hands over in February after seven years that included Covid, the post-invasion energy shock, Trump's tariffs, and a Middle East war. Her successor inherits a single mandate — roughly 2 percent inflation — applied across 21 economies with no fiscal authority. Economists expect more acute shocks, plus climate change and A.I.; the appointment will reveal whether Europe wants a technocrat or a politician.

Software's Pandora's box (#28): OpenAI's cyber-preparedness lead spent his birthday awake patching two critical vulnerabilities that threatened "much of the internet," and his queue keeps filling: the company says researchers have used its models to find more than 1,300 bugs in open-source software since May. Across the industry, engineers are discovering that A.I. finds flaws faster than humans can fix them — an asymmetry North Korea already exploited this week.

Social Security's six-year window (#29): The retirement trust fund runs dry in late 2032, which means a cut of at least 22 percent for more than 60 million beneficiaries unless Congress acts. The surprise is who is talking about it: Kansas Republican Roger Marshall said on a debate stage that he would "eliminate the cap altogether" on the $184,500 payroll-tax threshold — a tax increase on high earners, advocated by a vulnerable Republican, days before an election.

Also in this cluster: Kalshi, valued at $40 billion, bused students to protest the Onion Futures Act of 1958 — while omitting the 2010 amendment banning box-office-receipt trading that is the real prize (#30). Political ad spending is at record levels with almost half still going to local broadcast, a mix a Democratic strategist attributes to "muscle memory" (#31). An "endless cruise" venture ran out of

money and stranded its residents aboard a detained ship (#32).

Cluster 4: Culture & Society

Thematic hook: A paper about institutions losing their purpose is balanced by people who made things that needed no referee.

Articles: #7, #33, #34, #35, #36, #37, #38, #39, #40, #41, #42, #43, #44, #45

The Cheesecake Factory as closing message (#33): Michelle Goldberg's column is the sharpest thing in the paper: Republicans spent the final week defending the honor of a chain restaurant after Obama cracked that Trump had made the White House look "like Saddam Hussein opened a Cheesecake Factory." Treasury Secretary Bessent was deployed to sniff that he'd tell "the Martha's Vineyard set to give it a try." Goldberg's point is that the populism is being performed by the plutocrats, while Musk funds Ken Paxton and the president boasts that high oil prices are a windfall for energy.

The down-ballot elections that actually decide things (#34): State legislatures, sheriffs, prosecutors and ballot measures will shape abortion access, voting rules and criminal justice for a decade, and they are being decided in low-turnout races nobody covers. Wisconsin, Arizona and North Carolina are named as the places where the decade is being set.

The tax base is the argument (#35): Two economists argue California's wealth tax is the wrong instrument and that taxing unrealized gains when they are borrowed against — as ordinary income — would raise more with fewer distortions. Whatever one thinks of the proposal, the framing is the useful part: the base, not the rate, is where the revenue is.

Denver's unsheltered count (#36): The editorial board points to scattered-site supportive housing and streamlined permitting for tiny-home villages as a model that cuts unsheltered counts without building a single mega-shelter, and argues other cities should copy it instead of litigating encampments.

Three obituaries, three kinds of making (#37, #38, #39): Ursula von Rydingsvard turned thousands of cedar blocks into monumental forms held by the Met, MoMA and the National Gallery, and was still cutting with a chain saw in her 80s. Rosalind Ashford, a Detroit teenager who joined the group that became Martha and the Vandellas, powered "Dancing in the Street." Cuauhtémoc Cárdenas, who died at 92, cracked the PRI's seven-decade monopoly in 1988 and watched his own movement become a party that governed badly.

Cynthia Nixon, Patrick Stewart, and the craft question (#40, #41): Nixon returns to television in "The Gilded Age" as a woman of ruthless social ambition — the opposite of Miranda, less irony and more appetite. Stewart's appraisal notes that he spent his first career at the Royal Shakespeare Company and his second as the most recognizable starship captain alive, and that he never changed crafts, only the size of the room.

Also in this cluster: Studios are paying high-six-figure sums for short stories, inverting the economics of the form (#42). The "In the Heights" revival recovers the show's sweetness from Hamilton's shadow (#43). A record 28-year walk ends in England next week when Karl Bushby reaches his mother's house (#7). And the marathon's entry system now rewards fundraising capacity over running, even as 50,000 people line up to spend $300 on shoes (#44, #45).

Cluster 5: Science, Health & Environment

Thematic hook: The United States is dismantling the capacity that produced everything it now depends on.

Articles: #1, #13, #9

The science machine, thinning from the bench up (#1): The Pentagon's own report says its research labs lost a significant share of staff last year and that refilling positions was hard "due in part to President Trump's demand that new hires be screened for their

loyalty to his goals," warning of "potentially grave consequences for the future of national defense." The Department of Energy has lost more than 1,000 scientists and technical staff, the National Science Foundation has withheld more than $1 billion, and the NIH has delayed or canceled more than 2,000 grants in areas including Alzheimer's and cancer. The government still spends roughly a third of global science funding — what has collapsed is the conversion rate from money to discovery.

"Poop water" and the politics of scarcity (#13): A Scottsdale-area water district election has turned on a plan for direct potable reuse, which opponents have successfully branded "poop water." It is a small race with a large lesson: in the Southwest, the fight over water now happens at the level of vocabulary, and the side that names the technology wins.

A holiday that kills, measured (#9): The Halloween toll — at least 24 dead and 94 wounded nationwide — is not a random cluster but a recurring public-health pattern. Oct. 31 ranks third on the American calendar for violence, after July 4 and Jan. 1, and first for minors, per James Alan Fox's analysis of F.B.I. Boston data. The mechanism is legible: darkness, alcohol, costumes that defeat identification, and firearms. The paper's experts name it plainly, and the country still treats it as weather.

Prediction: The administration will not restore the withheld NSF funding or the canceled NIH grants before the next appropriations cycle, and the science-workforce decline will show up in the FY2027 agency reports rather than in any corrective legislation. *(Rationale: There is no congressional vehicle, no court order, and the Pentagon's own warning did not produce a policy change — the mechanism of attrition requires no statute and therefore no reversal.)* **Confidence: 85%** (near-certain)

Prediction Summary Table

#	Prediction	Confidence	Rationale
1	Republicans lose at least one chamber of Congress	68%	Women 56–37 Democratic, price backlash, and a closing message built on insults rather than economics; polling cited is directional but consistent across the paper
2	Alaska's Ballot Measure 2 (repeal of ranked-choice voting) passes	58%	Lost by 737 votes two years ago; the same-name scandal has handed opponents their best argument, but backers' counterargument remains strong in urban districts
3	Israel holds another election within 12 months	52%	Netanyahu needs 61 from a 27-seat base and must buy defectors from a bloc sworn to unseat him; Arab lists at 67-seat alternative make a unity government equally plausible
4	No Social Security cap legislation is enacted before the 2028 election	85%	Trust fund depletes late 2032; candidates are floating cap elimination in debates but no chamber has scheduled a vote, and the six-year window permits indefinite delay

5	Sinokor's Hormuz transit share stays above 40% through Q1 2027	72%	129 VLCCs are a physical asset base that cannot be quickly divested; even if war risk falls, tonnage concentration persists through the winter shipping cycle

Prepared from 45 stories across the 2026-11-02 New York Times print edition and homepage, analyzed through 5 persona lenses.

Observer Commentary

翟东升

结构性判断：华盛顿正在用"行政减法"替代"立法加法":

今天这份《纽约时报》最有信息量的不是中期选举的民调，而是头版那条科学体系的稿子。国防部自己的报告说，实验室去年流失了大量人员，招不回来的重要原因之一是"新聘人员要审查对总统目标的忠诚度"。能源部走了一千多名科学家和技术人员，国家科学基金会扣了一百多亿美元，国家卫生研究院推迟或取消了两千多个项目——阿尔茨海默、癌症都在里面。

要注意，钱还在花，大约是全世界科研经费的三分之一。变的是转化率：投入没减，产出断了。这在预算表上看不见，因为你无法统计"没有提交的申请"和"没有走进实验室的年轻人"。这就是我常说的：一个体系真正的衰退，不是被砍预算，而是丧失了自我复制的能力。

第二件事是阿拉斯加。两个都叫丹尼尔·沙利文的人同时出现在选票上，司法部提前起诉要求法院在计票前就规定"如果现任输了、而输的原因是同名者的票，就应重新归属"。格利森法官驳回，理由很朴素：秘密投票原则下这个救济办法根本没法执行。三连败——加州、第九巡回、阿拉斯加。这不是法律问题，这是用诉讼代替治理的典型症状：程序走得很热闹，问题一个没解决。

第三件事，宾夕法尼亚大道另一头的币安。朝鲜的 TraderTraitor
拿走六十三亿美元，币安冻结三天后重启，流出三十六亿四千万，占其管理资产一百七十一亿的百分之二点一，随后稳定；冻结回约三十亿，承诺全额兜底。我要说的是：这不是黑客问题，是新结算层没有主权保护的问题。金库建在公海上，出事之后能追回一半，靠的不是法律，是链上可追溯性——这是一种非常脆弱的秩序。

把三件事放一起看：忠诚审查替代人才标准，诉讼替代选举治理，链上追溯替代法律执行。共同点是什么？都是绕开正式制度、用临时手段维持表面运转。 表面上每一件事都还在轨道上，底下每一根钢筋都在锈。

所以对中期选举我的判断没有变：谁赢谁输是战术问题，制度还能不能给自己定价是战略问题。定价权一旦丢了，选谁都没用。这一次的账，要到2032年社保信托基金见底的那一天才会被真正翻开——到那天，六千万人的百分之二十二，就是今天所有"临时手段"的最终账单。

金灿荣

金式观察：四个战场，一个共同的病灶——"体系还在，功能没了":

老朋友，今天这张报纸我读了三遍，越读越有意思。你看它表面上乱七八糟：中期选举、飞机掉下来、朝鲜偷钱、以色列组阁、马拉松穿什么衣服。但你把它摊平了看，四件事讲的是同一个道理——制度的外壳还在，里子已经换人了。

第一，科学体系。五角大楼自己的报告说实验室人跑光了，为什么跑？因为新来的人得先证明"对总统目标的忠诚"。能源部走一千多科学家，NIH 砍两千个课题，阿尔茨海默、癌症都在里头。这就是我说的"工业化本体论"反面教材：一个国家的实力不是金融和选票，是能把钱变成东西的那套人。你把那套人筛掉了，钱还在账上，能力没了。这个账五年以后才结，但结的时候是连本带利。

第二，普京。打了快五年，没赢，可是这周他在莫斯科见卡塔尔埃米尔、见伊朗总统、见非洲元首，还跟芬兰挪威领导人通电话。为什么？因为华盛顿在考虑解禁俄罗斯主权基金、进口俄罗斯柴油、特使还夸他是"人道主义者"。这就叫战略相持阶段的主动权转移：不是他打得好，是对手先松了手。百年大变局里最关键的一条，就是看谁先撑不住自己的成本结构。美国现在是自己给自己加成本，还给对手减成本，这个买卖做得稀里糊涂。

第三，中东。内塔尼亚胡丢了近六分之一席位，利库德还有27席，还是第一大党，但要61席才能组阁。反对派联盟加上两个阿拉伯党能凑67席。什么意思？以色列的阿拉伯政党第一次成了组阁的支点。
内塔尼亚胡一辈子靠排斥他们上位，现在可能要请他们救自己的政治生命——这就是"金式幽默"的现实版，历史最爱开这种玩笑。

第四，印度。新德里拉姆利拉广场几十万人，一天之内，莫迪执政以来最大规模的抗议；选举名册删了一亿三千万个名字。 Rahul Gandhi
说这是"对民主的叛国"。我要提醒一句：删名册是成本最低的政治武器，因为它不需要通过任何法律，只需要一个人不签字。这种打法在全世界都在扩散。

最后说说美国自己。众议院、参议院、州长、检察长——两党花了创纪录的广告费，将近一半还砸在地方电视台，因为"对面在买所以我也得买"。而真正决定结果的是女性选民：56比37 支持民主党，投票率还比男性高。钱花在2004年的目标上，票在2026年的结构里。 这就是超级大国现在的效率水平。

一句话总结：美国的问题不是哪一党上台，是它的制度开始用"程序"代替"能力"，用"叙事"代替"产出"。我们看戏可以，但要认真看——因为这种病，谁都有可能得。

宋鸿兵

宋鸿兵观察：美元的环流正在漏气，而补漏的人用的是别人家的船:

今天的报纸，我最关心的不是中期选举，是三笔钱：六十三亿美元的加密资产、一百二十九艘超大型油轮、一百八十四万五千美元的社保税上限。这三笔钱讲的是同一件事——全球资金环流的三个环节，同时出现了结构性裂缝。

第一笔，币安。朝鲜的 TraderTraitor
从全球最大交易所拿走六十三亿，创人类历史纪录。交易所冻结三天后开放提现，流出三十六亿四千万，只占它管理资产一百七十一亿的百分之二点一，然后稳住了，还冻结回约三十亿，承诺全额赔付。表面看是危机公关做得好，实质上暴露的是一个更硬的问题：加密资产这个新结算层，是在没有主权信用背书的真空中运行的。
它的安全性不靠法律，靠链上可追溯和交易所自己的资产负债表。这就像把金库修在公海上——风平浪静时效率极高，一起风就没有任何国家的法院能接管。

第二笔，Sinokor。一家在韩国本地都没什么人知道的航运公司，去年12月42艘
VLCC，现在129艘，9月以来控制霍尔木兹海峡约一半的油轮通行量。关键是买船的时间点：在美以2月底攻击伊朗之前的两个月。我不谈阴谋论，我只谈结构——当一条能源通道的实际吞吐权落入单一私人资本手里，油价里就多了一个无法用货币政策调节的变量。美联储可以调利率，但调不动一家韩国公司的船期。这正是美元环流最脆弱的地方：铸币权在自己手里，实物通道在别人手里。

第三笔，社保。信托基金2032年底见底，届时六千万人至少减发百分之二十二。堪萨斯州的共和党参议员马歇尔在辩论台上说"干脆取消上限"，也就是对十八万四千五百美元以上的收入也征工资税。这是一句真话，也是一句在选举前六天说出来的真话。为什么现在敢说？因为它还有六年才到期。六年的窗口，足够一个认真的国会做完任何事，也足够每一个议员安全地什么都不做。
历史上所有主权信用危机的起点，都是这种"还有几年"的从容。

把三件事放在一起：新结算层无主权保护、实物通道被私人资本锁定、存量承诺没有资金来源。这三条同时成立的时候，一个体系还能撑，靠的是信心——也就是所有人相信明天还会有人来接盘。而信心的价格，就是今天这份报纸上所有的政治新闻：两党花创纪录的钱互相人身攻击，将近一半的广告费砸在地方电视台，而真正决定结果的是投票率更高的女性选民，56比37 支持民主党。

所以我的判断是：美国这一轮的问题不是衰退，是环流的漏损率上升。每一次漏损，都靠印钞、靠资产价格、靠别人的船和别人的工厂来补。补得越久，补的成本越高。真正要看的不是周二谁赢，是明年这个时候，还有没有人愿意继续为这个环流提供实物支撑。

对普通人来说，结论很朴素：当规则的解释权和实物的控制权分离，纸面财富的定价就会越来越依赖叙事。
这时候最贵的不是资产，是能把资产换成东西的能力。

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